

Reply
to
Pastor Zeuthen, *Dr. phil.*,
on the Occasion of His Open Letter
on Faith and Knowledge.

By
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Most esteemed Doctor!

We could, so far as I can see, come to agreement on very essential points, if only we could agree that a science of miracles, a science that explains miracles, belongs among the impossible things. You ask me in your Open Letter (p. 7) how one can declare it “a settled matter that science denies the wonder,” and you add straight afterwards: “As far as natural science is concerned, one must indeed grant that its concept of nature is not theological, and that it has no place for what we in the religious sense call the wonderful; but is natural science all science, the highest science?” I answer: that besides natural science there is indeed a science of ideas; but of this latter, in my view, three things hold: 1) it must be built on the mathematical-empirical foundation of the doctrine of nature; 2) it must, just as much as the doctrine of nature, be a cognition by virtue of laws; it can 3) not be thought to stand in any essential or principled conflict with the doctrine of nature. If, now, the doctrine of nature as science—as science, mark you—must deny the possibility that “one really dead” can really rise from the grave (so that no natural-scientific account whatsoever can be given of the miracle of the resurrection), then the doctrine of ideas, as surely as it would count as science, must deny the same. For the doctrine of nature would be false if, in its interpretation of the facts, it declared impossible what was nonetheless possible according to a scientific conception of the idea of nature; conversely, the doctrine of ideas would be [3] only hollow speculation if, by its extension of the possibilities, it came into conflict with the first inviolable principles of the doctrine of nature. To try to bring about a reconciliation between religion and science by sowing discord between science and science will in no way do.

The old dream—for I can now regard it as nothing other than a dream—of a highest science that should be able to find out the “thinkability” and “possibility” of the miracle rests, if I am not mistaken, on a couple of ambiguities: the ambiguity in the word *wonder*, and the ambiguity in the use theology makes of the teleological.

What is the wonder, when theology sets about treating it “objectively,” other than a great ambiguity? “Everything”—says an acute theologian—“is a wonder. Every event is the effect of the Godhead, grounded immediately in the divine power; but it shows itself as an effect of nature grounded mediately in God. In the objective sense, then, everything is wonder or nothing is wonder; the awakening of the seed to the life of spring is a wonder as much as the awakening of the dead from the grave, healing by

medicines as much as by the laying on of hands, and every point of support for the concept falls away. Nature's system of forces is a deep that is eternally unfathomable, and we only shame ourselves if we presume to draw boundary lines where there are none." But that a doctrine of ambiguity which places "the awakening of the dead from the grave" and "the awakening of the seed to the life of spring" on the same step in the series of possibilities is not exactly fitted to reconcile faith and knowledge, but ought rather to be assigned "a place of its own outside science," most people in our time will surely concede.

To the ambiguous use of the word wonder there corresponds in theology an equally ambiguous use of the words *teleology* and the *teleological*. For there is a difference, indeed a very essential difference, between a teleology that is the higher expression of the fulfilment of laws, a presentation of nature's real ends, and a fantastic teleology that soars above the laws of science. Since, then, it belongs in my opinion to the first requirements of philosophical culture to be oriented regarding the difference between [4] what is determined by law and what is fantastic, I long ago treated the ambiguities belonging here in the Propaedeutics, and I set down here, by way of example, a small specimen: "A. Do you suppose that the natural scientist's concept of the law of nature stands in an essential or in a merely accidental relation to natural science? C. In an essential one, naturally! A. You quoted above a passage from H. C. Ørsted's *The Spirit in Nature*, and will then also remember that in the same work there is an essay, 'The Relation of Natural Science to Several Important Objects of Religion,' whose first part, headed 'The Immutability of the Laws of Nature,' begins thus: 'In my book, *The Spirit in Nature*, I have with full conviction embraced the old doctrine of the immutability of the laws of nature....' But if the laws of nature are immutable, how are we then to interpret sentences such as these: 'The awakening of the seed to the life of spring is a wonder, as much as the awakening of the dead from the grave, healing by medicines as much as by the laying on of hands'? C. The hermeneutic key lies, surely, in the words: 'Every event is the working of the Godhead, grounded immediately in the divine power, but it shows itself as an effect of nature grounded mediately in God. In the objective sense, then, everything is wonder or nothing is wonder.' A. So if the dead awoke in the grave every spring, when the seed 'awakens to life,' the former would be in just as good agreement with 'the immutability of the laws of nature' as the latter? C. Yes, why not, if such an awakening really were *teleological*? For nature is"—here a sentence is borrowed from Dr. H. Martensen's "Christian Dogmatics"—"a system that finds itself in a continued teleological development, a continued creation!" Why

should the dead not be allowed to awaken every spring, provided only that they awoke teleologically, in accordance with a continued creation? A. That arsenic sulphide can turn into water, water into wine, wine into coal, and coal into gold, is then in perfect agreement with the immutability of the laws of nature? C. Provided, mark you, that it happens *teleologically*, in accordance with a continued creation! A. That a man [5] walks on the sea without sinking is then just as consonant with the immutability of the laws of nature as that someone falls into the water and drowns? C. Man, who is otherwise subject to the laws of gravity, can very well walk on the sea when it happens *teleologically*, in accordance with a continued creation! A. But then, as far as the immutability of the laws of nature is concerned, there is presumably nothing offensive to deeper thought, when we rightly consider it, in a Pope, Leo XII, having been able to beatify the Minorite Julianus, who in our unbelieving, revolutionary nineteenth century made roasted birds fly? C. That I for my part take the wonder of the roasted birds for a stupid fable, a priestly lie, does not arise at all from my seeing in the event itself any breach of the immutability of the laws of nature, but simply from my not being a Catholic and consequently being unable to convince myself that the event has taken place *teleologically*, in accordance with a *continued creation*. Were I a Catholic and had a Catholic's faith, I should surely be able to reconcile my faith with my knowledge, my concept of creation with my concept of nature; I should then surely, in consideration—indeed in dogmatic consideration—of the teleology in the roasted birds, be able to explain the miracle thus: "Nature"—here again a sentence is borrowed from Dr. H. Martensen's "Christian Dogmatics"—"does not deny the concept of creation, and the wonder is precisely the point at which nature's dependence on the creating freedom becomes perfectly manifest." If the eternal Reason, the triune God, the absolute Idea, wished to give us a sign that could show the unbelief of these times in a really conspicuous way that nature, a system that finds itself in a continued *teleological* development, does not deny the concept of creation: how could the eternal Reason, working according to *immutable laws of nature*, then choose a sign more *teleological* than precisely this sign of the Minorite's roasted birds? For this stands dogmatically firm: if the birds are roasted *teleologically*, in accordance with a process of nature continued in creation, then they must also be able to fly *teleologically*, in accordance with a process of creation continued in nature. A. You are a true theologian; you can reconcile faith and knowledge." (Lectures on [6] "Phil. Propæd." 1861–62; pp. 158–59).

In this short exchange, Doctor, you will surely find neither distortion nor exag-

generation. It is, after all, a well-known matter that the Catholic scholastic, leaning on the authority of the Church, set firmly on his medieval traditional foundation, has an altogether different assurance in explaining and defending his saints' miracles than the Protestant theologian, dazzled by the enlightenment of reason and entangled in seventeen half-scientific considerations, has in explaining the works either of Christ or of his Apostles.

To convince ourselves still further of what it comes to in reality when the supposedly higher science sets about explaining and grounding the wonders of revelation, we need only cast a glance at "the Christian Dogmatics"; for we have, happily, in our recent literature the dogmatics that can with reason be said to represent a summit of theological scientificity.

Yes, if any science should be able to explain the wonder, it would certainly have to be dogmatics. What, then, has our "Christian Dogmatics" brought forth toward a scientific understanding of the three fundamental wonders of revelation: *Creation, the Incarnation and Inspiration*?

Of *Creation* it is taught that God "brings forth a creature that at the same time brings forth and develops itself in given independence." If it is to be possible to connect any meaning with so obscure a sentence, the meaning must evidently be this: that the activity of the Creator is at the same time an activity of nature, that the wonder at the same time takes place in a natural way. With this it then certainly agrees that the world is created on the one side with necessity, on the other with freedom; on the one side out of nothing, on the other out of something; that creation is at bottom cosmogony, and cosmogony creation. "Judaism," it is said, "conceives the world predominantly as *creatura*, not as *natura*, as κτισις, not as φυσις. But just for that reason the whole significance of creation is not disclosed to Judaism"; and so on. Once the miracle has in this way become an event of nature and the event of nature a miracle, once nature and creation have been lumped together so that nature is to a certain degree created and the created is nature, then it becomes an easy matter to introduce gradations, not only in the "given independence" of the created, but in the miracle of creation itself; the one miracle of creation then becomes greater, stronger and more remarkable than the other: we get a dogmatic thermometer for miracles. Thus "the Christian Dogmatics" sees in Christ at once "the completed creation of human nature and the God become man himself," sees, in other words, how the Uncreated is himself created: this, now, is the very greatest miracle. The creation of "the first Adam" is indeed also a great miracle. "The first Adam is *created* in a sense [7]

in which none of his descendants is”; but this great miracle of creation nevertheless stands many degrees below the miracle of the Incarnation. Now, just as the miracle of the creation of the first Adam stands many speculative degrees below the miracle of the second, so the miracle of the creation of Eve, though in itself a respectable miracle, stands at least two and a half degrees below the miracle of the creation of Adam. So many degrees in the miracle of creation, so many meanings of the word creation! If the second Adam is created in a sense in which no other creature is; if the first Adam is created in a degree and sense in which none of his descendants is; if Eve is created in a degree and sense in which no other woman is; the heroes and the geniuses again created in other degrees and other senses than ordinary human beings: then one sees that the miracle-degrees of creation must be able to vary between great nodal points almost as continuously as the natural degrees of heat. This fluid—if at times viscous—unity of nature and creation then at last, by the addition of “traducianism” and “creatianism,” becomes remarkably thin. “It is the truth of traducianism that every human individual is an offspring of the natural activity of the race.” But it is “the truth of creatianism that this mysterious natural activity is the organ and means of God’s individualizing creative activity.” Creation has ceased, for it has been replaced [8] by preservation; but preservation is a continued creation, so creation has not ceased; creation has to a certain degree ceased, to a certain degree not ceased. This, in sum, is the explanation “the Christian Dogmatics” gives us of the wonder of creation.

And what does “the Christian Dogmatics” teach about the wonder of the Incarnation? Among other things the following: “When it has been found self-contradictory that the eternal Logos becomes man, ‘because the Eternal and Omnipresent cannot let himself be born in the midst of time,’ then it certainly cannot be the task to think that with the Incarnation the eternal Logos should cease to exist in his general revelation in the world, or that the Logos as a self-conscious personal being should be enclosed in a mother’s womb, be born as a child, grow in knowledge, and so on; for this notion annuls the very concept of birth. Birth in time necessarily brings with it the notion of a progression from the unconscious to the conscious, from possibility to actuality, from seed-corn and germ to full-grown organization. That the divine Logos lets himself be born therefore means that he sinks himself into the bosom of humanity as possibility, as holy seed, in order to be able to rise up in the midst of the human race in mediating and saving *human* revelation.” Here, then, we have the explanation. But, Doctor, could we not easily agree that this explanation itself stands in great need of an explanation? For what is it that the divine Logos has properly “sunk” into “the

bosom of humanity”: *himself* or *not himself*? If it is not himself, not his proper self, then neither is it the Logos himself that is incarnate. The being whose proper self cannot be “sunk” as possibility into a mother’s womb cannot be incarnated. But if it really is himself, his possible, essential self, yet not the eternally self-conscious personal self of which we are speaking here: then the divine Logos must have a double self, one that can be incarnated and one that cannot be incarnated. The Logos that can be incarnated is therefore in himself, in his proper self, another than the eternal personal Logos himself; in other words: according to the explanation of “the Christian Dogmatics,” the eternal personal Logos himself has not become incarnate at all. [9]

And what interpretation, finally, does “the Christian Dogmatics” give us of the wonder of Inspiration? It is the event at the feast of Pentecost (Acts, ch. 2, vv. 1–12). The sound from heaven, the rushing mighty wind, the tongues of fire, the gifts of tongues, that “they were all filled with the Holy Ghost, and began to speak with other tongues, as the Spirit gave them utterance”—this was what was to be explained. “The new creation,” says the Dogmatics, “in no respect falls short of the old as far as the miraculous is concerned; here ‘a supernatural beginning’ is made.” But if we look more closely, then by dogmatic-scientific measurement of degrees—for the miracle of the Spirit naturally has its degrees and gradations too—the miracle has been placed so peculiarly that it almost looks as though “the process of nature” in “the new creation” had gained a disquieting preponderance over “the process of creation.” For the state in which the Apostles found themselves when at the feast of Pentecost they began to speak with tongues is described as “a state in which consciousness is not master of itself, a state of ecstasy, of rapture, which was the expression of the breaking through and stirring of the new spiritual powers in the depths of the soul, and which bore the stamp of a spiritual state of nature rather than of the clear life of consciousness”; truly, among the many “processes of creation” of sacred history, a most remarkable “process of nature”! That this “spiritual state of nature” of “ecstasy” and “rapture” must have lasted rather long and worked on a considerable scale is especially evident from the remarkable influence it has exercised on the author of the Acts of the Apostles. For the Evangelist Luke, undoubtedly on account of a certain “spiritual state of nature,” has come in his account to stand the whole miracle on its head. What Luke relates is, as is well known, this: that the “devout men, out of every nation under heaven” heard the Apostles speak in such a way that they “were amazed and marvelled, saying one to another, Behold, are not all these which speak Galilaeans? And how hear we them speak, every man in our own tongue, wherein we were born? Parthians, and [10]

Medes, and Elamites, and we that dwell in Mesopotamia, Judaea, and Cappadocia, Pontus and Asia, in Phrygia and Pamphylia, the parts of Egypt and of Libya, about Cyrene, and we Romans that dwell here, Jews and proselytes, Cretes and Arabians? *we do hear them declare the great works of God in our tongues.*” More clearly, more fully and more solemnly the author could not have expressed himself, if he wished precisely to lay weight on the wonder’s showing itself just in the gift of tongues, and the gift of tongues in this: that the simple Galileans, people who must otherwise be supposed able to speak only one single language, suddenly, by the prompting of the Spirit, came to speak the many different foreign languages. The Dogmatics, which has speculated the miracle out, knows better, however. “The Christian Dogmatics” declares expressly “that it is not necessary to think here of different languages, but of the circumstance that ‘they’” (devout men out of every nation under heaven) “each for himself felt addressed in his own innermost *peculiarity*, that the inner man in each was so addressed by this tongue of rapture that the soul felt itself released from its accustomed, its natural limitation and in a wonderful manner became manifest to itself.” By this explanation, then, the miracle of Pentecost has literally been turned upside down. The miracle which in “the Acts of the Apostles” happens to the Apostles is explained in “the Dogmatics” by “a state in which consciousness is not master of itself,” and is to that extent to be regarded as an improper miracle; whereas the natural joy and astonishment of the foreign “devout men” at that improper miracle is transformed in “the Christian Dogmatics” into the proper miracle, namely the miracle that every one of those present, although he “in a wonderful manner became manifest to himself”—so that here, in this respect, there could be no thought of illusion—was nevertheless (naturally by the miracle; for such a thing is possible only by a miracle) placed under the illusion that, in hearing a tongue “wherein” he was notoriously not born, he precisely imagined he heard “the tongue wherein he was born.”

If now these specimens of the profound “searchings” and objective explanations [11] of our “Christian Dogmatics” make an impression on you, Doctor, similar to the one they make on me, then we shall soon agree to give up the hope of the supposedly higher science, the science of miracles explained in the Spirit.

It is the miracle and again the miracle that, in the strictest sense, ties knots for science. We cannot untie these knots; let us honestly admit it: there is no other way out! Yet what am I saying? There is a way out after all, namely the way out of covering the knots with a couple of “valuable wisps of straw” and pouring nonsense over the “wisps of straw.” This is undeniably a way out, as far as the treatment is

concerned. But against it this must be said: the treatment is not scientific; and the scientific was supposed to lie in the treatment.

Science is not religious, religion not scientific; astronomy is not devout, devotion not scientific; mathematics is not prayerful, prayer not scientific; botany is without sacrament, the sacrament is not scientific. But however convinced I am that faith and knowledge, religion and science must—for the sake of a higher reconciliation—sue for divorce, and that theology, therefore, which as mediator would wear the cloak on both the religious and the scientific shoulder, must go; just as convinced am I that a revelation which has “the Word of Life” in itself must also have the light in itself; that there must, in other words, be a religious thinking, thorough, clear, convincing, a thinking which, in accordance with its peculiar presuppositions, neither is nor can be nor will be scientific, but which nonetheless in sharpness, certainty, endurance and consistency is a match for science.

You remind me (Open Letter, p. 9) of Ørsted’s words: “With truth the good is indissolubly bound, and the *full* truth brings its own comfort with it,” adding with reason: “it is by virtue of a faith, a trust, and so by virtue of his subjectivity, that he says this. But how should one come to the cognition of the full truth if one would not *respect* the factual? So long as something given in experience remains standing and testifies against the theory one has formed, the theory cannot be true. But to what is thus given there may also belong the human heart’s *need* for a living God and for his grace, so that only in faith in it can it find peace.” In this I am now wholly and entirely agreed with you, Doctor, just as we also agree that “God as the *product of thought* cannot be the object of faith.” [12]

But how are we to come to agreement about the remarkable relation in which you (Open Letter, p. 11) have placed the God of faith to human reason? It looks to me somewhat questionable. For if by reason and reason, thinking and thinking, I am to think the same thing in both sentences, then it is truly a difficult piece. Let me repeat what stands here: the God of faith can, you say, *to that extent* (namely, as the God who is the product of thought cannot be the object of faith) be called “the true abyss for human reason”; and immediately thereupon you add: “But the God of faith must then” (namely, when he is “the true abyss for human reason”) “be more than this, more than him at whom all reason, all thinking must stop”... How, I ask, can the God of faith both be “the *true* abyss for human reason” and yet still more than the true abyss, and so an abyss to such a degree that he is not an abyss; or—let us now consider properly how “it must be thought”—is the God of faith perhaps an abyss that

stops human reason in such a way that the abyss itself stops before reason, just as reason was to stop before the abyss; or is it perhaps so, that the abyss becomes reason while reason becomes abyss; or perhaps so, that reason first stops before the true abyss when it does not stop at all; or perhaps... Doctor, that piece about the abyss has a strange aftertaste! It tastes speculatively of "Christian Dogmatics"; I cannot get it down.

You ask (p. 12): "Do not truth and goodness really stand in so essential a relation [13] to God that one cannot be said to have any practical cognition of God at all, if one does not assume this union of truth and goodness with God?" I answer: that the believer must certainly assume that truth and goodness are united in God; but that a science of this union is, in my view, impossible is seen directly from the opposition between the idea of truth and the idea of goodness on which my conception of the difference in principle between theoretical and practical, scientific and religious cognition is founded. I by no means overlook the interaction between truth and goodness, between the ideals of thought and of will. "It goes without saying," I have indeed said, "that the ideals of thought and will must be able to enter into just as many-sided an interrelation as thought and will themselves; every attempt to draw a definitively fixed boundary line that would separate theoretical cognition from practical is to that extent unreasonable and meaningless. But there is here nonetheless a boundary, a difference in principle, which arises from the fact that in theory all the powers of the soul are subordinated to thinking, whereas in practice they are subordinated to the will." (Om theoretisk og praktisk Erkjendelse, p. 10). You have here misunderstood my popular exposition, as though I set the will up beside thought in an external way and, with one-sided attention to the practical, had an eye only for the proposition *bonum est, quia deus vult*, but forgot "to add the other as no less justified: *deus vult, quia bonum est*." On this occasion, Doctor, I should not like to burden you with metaphysical sentences, for I know from experience that such things lead nowhere; but if at some convenient moment you should come to leaf through Grundideernes Logik II (pp. 363–84), you would easily convince yourself that over the proposition *bonum est, quia deus vult* I have by no means forgotten its opposite: *deus vult, quia bonum est*.

You think (Open Letter, p. 11) that I wrongly make religion practical from first [14] to last, as though it were not "bound by any essential bond to a knowledge and to theoretical cognition, as though in religion thoughts meant nothing at all in and for themselves, but were exclusively practical and subordinate to the will." But when

you then, on this presupposition (Open Letter, p. 15), refer expressly to Scripture and declare that “the more one strives, seeking nourishment for one’s faith, to live oneself into Scripture, the more it summons us to *thinking* about the highest objects, a thinking not only of a practical but also of a theoretical kind”; then I wager ten to one, Doctor, that you are here confusing, in an altogether unclear way, *religious thinking*—or, if you will, *religious theory*—with scientific thinking. Wherever in the world have you come to take the “learning,” the “knowledge” and the “wisdom” of which Christ and the Apostles speak for scientific knowledge? Has Christ, then, really the character of a man of science? Have isagogics, hermeneutics, exegetics, apologetics and dogmatics perhaps, by united endeavours, at last brought it so far that Christ’s words, cited by you yourself (Matthew 11, 25: “I praise thee, Father, that thou hast hid these things from the wise and prudent, and hast revealed them unto babes”), can now really be taken as a kind of scientific introduction—an introduction to the science of miracles, the science that will kindly explain the miracles to us? Or how has it been possible for you, in one and the same breath, to cite the two passages of Paul, first 1 Cor. 1, 14, “the word of the Lord by the prophet: I will cast away the wisdom of the wise, and bring to nothing the understanding of the prudent,” and then the prayer for the Colossians, “that they might be filled with the cognition of God’s will in all wisdom and spiritual understanding” (Col. 1, 9), and here think of scientific wisdom, scientific understanding? I see well enough that you have emphasized the words *all wisdom and spiritual understanding*; but I see also that you have forgotten to emphasize the words *the cognition of God’s will*. Had you noticed that the cognition of which Paul speaks is precisely the cognition of *God’s will*, you could not possibly [15] have overlooked that this cognition of the will, for all theory, is and remains of a practical kind.

You say (Open Letter, p. 17): “Besides the testimony of the Church and of Scripture one knows, after all, that of the *Spirit*, the testimony of the Holy Ghost. Should there not be a *scientific* expression for this testimony, so that one might have in it a principle well in accord with the Church and Scripture, yet not drawn from their testimony?”^{*)} This expectation will be disappointed. It is, after all, a fact that the Greek-Catholic theologian has appealed to the testimony of the Holy Ghost just as much as the Roman-Catholic, the Reformed theologian just as much as the Lutheran; and what

^{*)}From Grundideernes Logik I (pp. 48–53; 239–43) and II (pp. 151–57; 343–47) it may be seen that from the standpoint of knowledge I have by no means been without attention to what the theologians call *testimonium spiritus*.

has been the consequence? That the one, by virtue of “the testimony of the Spirit,” has pronounced a curse upon the other! So it is when we look at the history of the Church. If we look at the origin, then the Holy Ghost gives itself its very mightiest testimony in Inspiration. What, now, according to the Apostle Peter’s speech (Acts 2, 14–32), is this testimony? “And it shall come to pass in the last days, saith God, I will pour out of my Spirit upon all flesh: and your sons and your daughters shall prophesy, and your young men shall see visions, and your old men shall dream dreams,” and so on; but such a testimony does not point in a scientific direction.

How religious cognition, from the standpoint of religion, will come to relate itself to scientific cognition is a great and comprehensive problem, whose solution must be attempted in a philosophy of religion; but a philosophy of religion that is to solve the task in any degree must then know how to set the light of knowledge in such a way that, instead of casting a confusing twilight glimmer over the miracles, it can illuminate from all sides the religious independence of the principle of will, and therewith of the principle of revelation and of faith. [16]

What I have here, in all brevity, written in reply to your esteemed Open Letter, I now ask you, Doctor, to receive with goodwill for closer consideration. We could, as I said, come to agreement on very essential points, if only we could agree that a science that explains miracles, a science of miracles, belongs among the impossible things.
